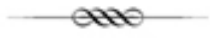
beginning of Indira Gandhi's policy of 'family before nation'. Emboldened by his enhanced clout, Sanjay started influencing his mother's political decisions also. Soon after the declaration of Emergency, Sanjay Gandhi started approaching Swaran Singh's senior private secretary, Z.S. Bains, with recommendations for the grant of defence ministry-related contracts. Swaran Singh told Bains to convey to Sanjay that such recommendations should be routed through Sanjay's mother, which never happened.

Swaran Singh resigned from Indira Gandhi's cabinet in November 1975, after having served a record uninterrupted twenty-three years as cabinet minister under three prime ministers. Interestingly, Singh was replaced by Bansi Lal as defence minister. Given the changed political environment, an insecure Indira started leaning heavily for support on Sanjay, and after his death in July 1980, on her elder son Rajiv and some of his friends, all extra-constitutional entities.



While I was in Canada, the Congress lost the Punjab state elections in 1977 to the Akali Dal-Janata Party coalition led by Parkash Singh Badal. Soon after this, some sketchy details reached me about former chief minister Giani Zail Singh and Sanjay Gandhi trying to destabilize the Akali Dal-led coalition government by enlisting the support of Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale of Chowk Mehta gurudwara. Efforts were also being made to plant pro-Khalistan ideas in the minds of Sikhs in Punjab and to link that demand to Bhindranwale.

Further details came to my attention on my return to headquarters in October 1979. I realized that what was happening in Punjab since 1978 was a sort of special operation launched by Sanjay Gandhi and Giani Zail Singh, the details of which have been mentioned in the Preface. That was also the time when Sanjay Gandhi and Kamal Nath were trying to topple Prime Minister Morarji Desai's government at the Centre by working on the disgruntled Janata Party leader Raj Narain. They were able to achieve this objective in July 1979.